

The Descent That Raises

An essay on Humility, Meekness and Submission (M09)

If pride is the self made high, this family is its exact reverse: the self made low — brought low, or bringing itself low — before God and under those God has set over it. But the family carries a paradox at its centre, and the paradox is the point. The low place is not where a person is lost; it is where grace is found. "God opposes the proud but gives grace to the humble" (Jam 4:6). "Humble yourselves before the Lord, and he will exalt you" (Jam 4:10). The way down, in this region of the inner life, turns out to be the way up.

The words gather into a small, well-ordered field. There is a humility proper — being low — that sorts itself by *how* the lowering happens: whether a person chooses it, settles into it, or has it imposed. There is an authority pair — obedience and submission — by which the lowered self orders itself under another. There is a willing heart that makes all of this freely given rather than merely extracted. And there are two quieter edges, dignity and gentleness, that border on neighbouring things. Underneath them all runs one figure: Christ, who "humbled himself" (Phili 2:8).

The three voices of being low

Humility proper speaks in three voices. The first is the chosen act — a person deliberately lowering himself before God, almost always in repentance. "Hezekiah humbled himself for the pride of his heart" (2Ch 32:26); "your heart was penitent... you humbled yourself before the Lord" (2Ki 22:19); the promise hangs on it — "if my people... humble themselves, and pray" (2Ch 7:14). This is the humility a person *does*, and it is the one form in the family that is never God's own act: the creature alone bends. It is summed up in a single walking instruction: "walk humbly with your God" (Mic 6:8).

The second voice is not an act but a settled disposition — lowliness as the abiding shape of a person's heart. Here humility is something a person *is*: "I am gentle and lowly in heart" (Mat 11:29), says the One who alone holds it perfectly. It shows itself outward as the esteem of others — "count others more significant than yourselves" (Phili 2:3) — and it is something to be deliberately worn, like clothing: "put on... humility, meekness, and patience" (Col 3:12); "with all humility and gentleness" (Eph 4:2). Where the first voice is an event, this one is a temperature — the constant lowliness that "associate[s] with the lowly" (Rom 12:16).

The third voice is the hardest: lowness not chosen and not cultivated, but imposed. To be brought low — by God, by enemies, by want. Mary names it of herself: "he has looked on the humble estate of his servant" (Luk 1:48). Paul names it of his circumstances: "I know how to be brought low" (Phili 4:12). It has a felt, inward correlate — the bowed and downcast heart — and a God who meets it there: "God, who comforts the downcast" (2Cor 7:6); "he bowed

their hearts down with hard labour" (Psa 107:12). This third voice is where humility touches suffering, and where it most needs the paradox to be true.

Ordered under another

From being low, the family turns to placing oneself low — under an authority. Two postures do this, close in meaning but distinct in flavour. The first is obedience: the inner submission of the will — the will that, in the root sense of the word, "hears under." It is meant to run deeper than mere compliance — "obedient from the heart" (Rom 6:17), "with a sincere heart" (Eph 6:5). And it has two directions at once. It is owed to God — "the obedience of faith" (Rom 1:5), the souls "purified... by your obedience" (1Pe 1:22) — and it is owed within ordinary human order: "Children, obey your parents" (Eph 6:1). Even the Son walked this road: "he learned obedience through what he suffered" (Heb 5:8).

The second posture is submission — less the active complying than the settled ordering of oneself beneath another. "Let a woman learn quietly with all submissiveness" (1Ti 2:11); "be subject to the elders... clothe yourselves... with humility" (1Pe 5:5). Submission is the quieter of the two: not so much doing what is commanded as taking the lower place and keeping it. And it has a limit that proves it is a servant of the truth and not its master — there is a submission that must be refused when it would betray the gospel.

The willing heart

What keeps all this from being mere subjugation is a single interior thing: a willing heart. Obedience and submission can be extracted by force, but in this family they are meant to be *given* — and what gives them is gladness of will. Scripture prizes "whoever is of a generous heart" (Exo 35:5), the freewill offering brought because the giver wanted to. And because such willingness is not native to us, it is asked for as a gift: "uphold me with a willing spirit" (Psa 51:12). This is the hinge between humility and joy — the low place owned freely, not endured resentfully.

Two further notes lie at the family's edge, each leaning toward a neighbour. There is dignity — a weighty, seemly bearing — which sits beside humility in the call to live "godly and dignified in every way" (1Ti 2:2), though it points more toward reverence than lowliness. And there is gentle forbearance — dealing softly with those who fail because one shares their weakness: a priest who "can deal gently with the ignorant and wayward" (Heb 5:2). Both are real, and both belong more to the borders of this region than its centre.

The reversal, and the One who made it

Hold the whole family together and one figure stands at its source. The chosen self-humbling, the lowly heart, the borne humiliation, the obedience — each is first true of Christ. He "humbled himself by becoming obedient to the point of death" (Phili 2:8); he is the One "gentle and lowly in heart" (Mat 11:29); and "by the one man's obedience the many will be made righteous" (Rom 5:19). What in us is repentance was in him pure descent, freely chosen.

And his story is the proof of the family's paradox. The pattern that governs the whole region is a reversal — the low raised, the high brought down: "he has brought down the mighty... and exalted those of humble estate" (Luk 1:52); "whoever humbles himself will be exalted" (Luk 18:14; Mat 23:12). It is no accident that the same sentence that warns the proud blesses the lowly — "God opposes the proud but gives grace to the humble" (Jam 4:6) — for pride and humility are the two halves of one truth, told from opposite ends. The proud self climbs to an empty throne and is brought down. The humble self takes the low place "under the mighty hand of God" (1Pe 5:6) and is lifted up — in his time, and after his pattern. The descent, in this family, is the thing that raises.